Practical 5

PERFORMING AN ANTENATAL ABDOMINAL EXAMINATION

Definition

Examination of a pregnant woman to determine the normalcy of fetal growth in relation to the gestational age, position of fetus in uterus and its relationship to the maternal pelvis.

Purposes

- To measure the SFH (Symphysis fundel height) and fundal height.
- To assess fetel size and growth.
- To determine abdominal muscle tone.
- To determine the fetal position, presentation, volume of liquid.
- To observe the signs of pregnancy.
- To detect any deviation from normal.
- To assess the fetel well being/
- To measure the abdominal girth.

Articles

- Fetoscope/stethoscope
- Measuring tape
- Tray contains / Sheet, Towel

Procedure

S No	Nursing action	Rational/scientific principle
1.	Explain the procedure and obtain her consent.	Reduces anxiety and promotes relaxation Avoids discomfort during palpation.
2.	Instruct her to empty the bladder	
3.	Position the women	
4	Expose her abdomen from below the breast to the symphysis pubis.	Visualization of the whole abdomen.
5.	Inspect abdomen for scars, linea nigra, size straie gravidarum, contourof abdomen, shape, state of umbilicus and skin condition.	It provides whether fetal growth corresponds to gestational period.
6.	Determine the fundal height using the ulnar side of the palm. Measure fundal height using the inch tape.	The number of centimeter measured should be approximately equal to the weeks of gestation after 24 weeks.
7.	Measure the abdominal girth by encircling the woman's abdomen with a tape measure at the level of umblicus. Abdominal palpation: Hands are warm before palpation.	Normally the measurement is 2 cm less or more than the weeks of gestation (eg) 32 cm or 36 cm in 34 weeks gestation Cold hands may cause muscle contraction and discomfort.

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